

MODULE 34 / 40

Gray Catbird

Dumetella carolinensis

QUICK STATS

Length	8.3 – 9.4 in (21 – 24 cm)
Wingspan	8.7 – 11.8 in (22 – 30 cm)
Weight	0.8 – 2.0 oz (23 – 56 g)
Lifespan	Up to 17 years (avg. 2–3 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Gray Catbird is a sleek, charcoal-gray songbird of dense thickets and woodland edges — a close relative of the Northern Mockingbird that shares its talent for mimicry but delivers its songs in a more rambling, improvisational style. Its common name comes from its most distinctive call: a nasal, descending "mew" that sounds remarkably like a cat. Slate gray overall with a black cap and a hidden chestnut patch under the tail, it is elegant in its simplicity. Despite being a common backyard bird across much of the eastern United States and southern Canada, it is often heard far more than it is seen, preferring to sing from deep within dense shrubs.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Gray Catbird breeds across the eastern two-thirds of North America, from southern Canada through the eastern and central United States, and winters along the Gulf Coast, Florida, the Caribbean, and Central America. It is a bird of dense, shrubby habitats: woodland edges, hedgerows, overgrown fields, suburban gardens with thick plantings, and the margins of streams and wetlands. It shows a particular affinity for areas with dense fruiting shrubs and tangles of multiflora rose, blackberry, and elderberry.

DIET & FEEDING

- Wild berries: blackberry, elderberry, holly, dogwood, multiflora rose
- Insects and spiders — dominant diet in summer, especially for nestlings
- Small fruits: cherry, serviceberry, blueberry, pokeweed
- Ants, beetles, caterpillars, and grasshoppers gleaned from foliage
- Occasionally visits platform feeders for halved grapes or fruit
- Tree sap at sapsucker wells in early spring

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Gray Catbirds are bold, curious, and often surprisingly tame — they will approach a quiet observer closely and scold with their distinctive cat-mew call. They are fierce nest defenders, attacking crows, raccoons, and domestic cats that approach the nest. Uniquely among mimic thrushes, the Gray Catbird is a cowbird "rejecter" — it recognizes and removes Brown-headed Cowbird eggs from its nest with remarkable reliability, making it one of the few common species that successfully resists brood parasitism. Outside the breeding season they are largely solitary.

NESTING & BREEDING

Gray Catbirds build a bulky, loosely constructed cup nest of twigs, bark strips, leaves, and grass, placed deep in a dense shrub or small tree 3–10 feet above the ground. The female incubates 2–6 deep turquoise-green eggs (one of the most vivid egg colors of any North American bird) for 12–15 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 10–12 days. Pairs raise 1–2 broods per season and aggressively defend the nest area.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Gray Catbird's song is a long, continuous, wandering medley of musical phrases, squeaks, whistles, and mimicry — delivered at a leisurely pace with no phrase repeated consecutively (unlike the Mockingbird, which repeats each phrase 3–5 times). It mimics other birds, frogs, and mechanical sounds with skill. The signature call is the cat-like "mew" — a descending, nasal note heard year-round. An aggressive "wrenk" alarm is given near the nest.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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The Gray Catbird population is estimated at 29 million individuals and is broadly stable. It has adapted well to suburban environments and is one of the more resilient neotropical migrants. Habitat loss on Caribbean wintering grounds, window collisions during migration, and cat predation at nest sites are the primary threats. Planting dense native fruiting shrubs and keeping cats indoors during nesting season are effective support strategies.

FEEDER TIPS

- Offer halved grapes, blueberries, or sliced fruit on a platform feeder
- Plant elderberry, blackberry, and native viburnums — far more effective than feeders
- Catbirds love dense thickets — leave hedgerows and shrubby tangles in place
- A shallow birdbath near dense cover is strongly attractive
- Listen for the cat-mew call in dense shrubs — the bird is usually just inside

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Overall plumage	Uniform slate gray
Cap	Black — distinctive
Undertail coverts	Chestnut-rufous — key field mark
Tail	Long, dark gray, often cocked upward
Eye	Dark — set in plain gray face
Bill	Short, dark, slightly curved

COLOR ME!

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